mostly a hagiographical and not a historical work. It is written to buttress Buddhism by highlighting the fact of a great monarch transformed by its tenets.

Modern readers are more fortunate than their ancient counterparts in that, because of the extensiveness of its ruins, they can imagine what ancient Taxila was like. This emerged from the long and detailed excavations conducted by the ASI under John Marshall for two decades or so from 1913. The ruins so patiently unearthed over long years still stand, testimony of the historical settlement which Ashoka apparently beheld as a young man.[6] The archaeological record of Taxila, it needs to be said, is very different from the narrative of the *Ashokavadana*. Dated imperial and official inscriptions, which can shore up the plausibility of events mentioned in ancient sources, are rare in India, as they are in large parts of the ancient world.[7] So an episode such as the arrival of an armed Mauryan prince and his party at Taxila has left no material trace at all and is basically unconnected with what has been identified by the excavations, namely the building and rebuilding of houses and streets, the changing stratigraphic features, and some events that may have influenced those changes. This makes it possible to describe the kind of city that Taxila was, and the quality of life of its citizens in Ashokan times.

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To reach Taxila the prince of Pataliputra would have traversed an enormous distance, nearly 2000 km, that being roughly the distance between present-day Patna and Punjab. The journey will have been across a vast crescent of alluvium created by the Ganga and its tributaries in the east and the Indus and smaller rivers that joined its flow towards the west. In the third century BCE, there will have been some open grassland and stretches cleared for cultivation, but large parts of the tracts were thickly forested. References in ancient texts like the *Mahabharata*, as also pollen records and charred